Lantern Hill College

Staff Handbook

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A fictional handbook created to demonstrate Pinpage. All names, places and contacts are invented.

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1. Introduction

1.1 About Lantern Hill College

Lantern Hill College is a fictional private college in Lekki, Lagos, created for demonstration purposes. It offers diploma and foundation programmes in business administration, computing, nursing support and creative media to around 1,400 students each year. The College employs 162 staff across four faculties and six support departments.

The College was founded in 2009 by a group of former lecturers who wanted to build a teaching institution that treats staff as professionals and students as partners. That founding idea still shapes how we write our policies: we explain the reason behind each rule, we give people a fair hearing, and we put decisions in writing.

Our main campus is on Admiralty Way. A smaller annex on Freedom Way houses the Faculty of Creative Media and the student counselling unit. Both sites follow the same policies unless this handbook says otherwise.

1.2 Purpose of this handbook

This handbook explains the terms, policies and everyday procedures that apply to every member of staff at Lantern Hill College. It is a practical guide. It tells you what you are entitled to, what the College expects of you, and who to speak to when something is unclear.

The handbook works alongside your individual contract of employment. Where your contract gives you a more generous term than this handbook, your contract applies. Where this handbook and a law of the Federal Republic of Nigeria or Lagos State disagree, the law applies.

Every member of staff receives a copy of the handbook during induction and is asked to confirm in writing that they have read it. Line managers are expected to know the sections that apply to their teams and to answer routine questions before referring them to Human Resources.

1.3 Who this handbook applies to

The handbook applies to all permanent and fixed term employees, whether full time or part time. Visiting lecturers, contractors and agency workers are covered only by Section 9 on conduct, Section 10 on health and safety and Section 11 on information and data protection.

Interns and students on placement are covered by a separate placement agreement. Their supervisors should read Section 9 carefully, because the conduct standards apply to everyone working on College premises.

1.4 Changes to policies

The College reviews this handbook every year in June. Human Resources consults the Staff Council on any proposed change at least 30 days before it takes effect, and publishes the final version on the staff portal by the first working day of September.

If an urgent change is needed during the year, for example because the law changes, Human Resources will email all staff with a summary of the change, the reason for it and the date it applies from. The change is then included in the next annual edition.

2. Working Hours and Attendance

2.1 Standard working hours

Full time staff work 40 hours a week, Monday to Friday. Standard hours are 8:00 am to 4:30 pm, including an unpaid lunch break of 30 minutes. Teaching timetables may require some lecturers to start at 7:30 am or finish at 6:00 pm on particular days; these hours are agreed with the Head of Faculty at the start of each term.

Part time staff work the hours set out in their contract. Their entitlements to leave and other benefits are calculated in proportion to the hours they work, as explained in Section 4.

Staff who work in student services, security and facilities may work on a rota that includes Saturdays. Rota staff still work 40 hours a week on average over a four week period, and receive one full rest day for every Saturday worked.

2.2 Flexible working

Any member of staff who has completed probation may ask for flexible working, such as compressed hours, a later start time or a reduced week. Requests are made in writing to the line manager using the flexible working form on the staff portal.

The line manager must meet the member of staff within 14 days of receiving the request and give a written decision within 28 days. A request can be refused only for a clear business reason, such as an effect on teaching cover or student safety, and the reason must be explained in the decision.

Staff may appeal a refusal to the Head of Human Resources within 10 working days. Only one flexible working request may be made in any 12 month period, unless circumstances change significantly, for example after the birth of a child.

2.3 Remote work

Teaching must take place on campus unless a programme has been approved for online delivery. Administrative staff may work from home for up to two days a week with their line manager's agreement, provided their duties can be done remotely and they are reachable during core hours of 10:00 am to 3:00 pm.

Staff working remotely must use College equipment or an approved personal device, keep student information private, and follow Section 11 on information and data protection. The College does not pay for home internet or electricity costs.

2.4 Lateness and absence reporting

If you will be late or absent for any reason, you must tell your line manager by telephone or WhatsApp no later than 7:30 am on the day. A message to a colleague is not enough. Lecturers must also inform the faculty office so that cover can be arranged for their classes.

Lateness of more than 15 minutes on three occasions within a calendar month will be discussed informally with your line manager. Repeated lateness after that discussion may be handled under the disciplinary procedure in Section 8.

Absence without notice for three consecutive working days, where the College has been unable to contact you, may be treated as abandonment of employment after the College has made reasonable efforts to reach you and your listed emergency contact.

3. Pay and Benefits

3.1 Salary payment

Salaries are paid monthly by bank transfer on the 25th day of each month. If the 25th falls on a weekend or public holiday, payment is made on the last working day before it. Payslips are available on the staff portal two days before payment.

Staff must tell the Finance Office in writing of any change to their bank details at least 10 working days before the next pay date. The Finance Office will confirm the change by phone before it takes effect, to protect staff against fraud.

Any error on a payslip should be reported to the Finance Office within one month. Overpayments will be recovered in agreed instalments over no more than six months, and underpayments will be corrected in the next salary payment.

3.2 Annual salary review

Salaries are reviewed every year in July, with any increase applied from the August salary. The review considers the College's financial position, inflation, and the outcome of each staff member's performance review described in Section 7.

Staff who are still on probation at the time of the review are not eligible for an increase that year, but their salary will be reviewed again when probation is completed.

3.3 Allowances

Full time staff receive a monthly transport allowance of 40,000 naira and a monthly meal allowance of 25,000 naira, paid with salary. Part time staff receive these allowances in proportion to their contracted hours.

Lecturers who supervise final year projects receive a supervision allowance of 15,000 naira per student per semester, up to a maximum of eight students. Staff who serve as examination invigilators outside their normal hours are paid 6,000 naira per session.

3.4 Health insurance and pension

All permanent staff and up to four registered dependants are covered by the College's health maintenance organisation plan from their first day of employment. Details of the plan and the list of approved hospitals are on the staff portal.

The College operates the contributory pension scheme required by law. The College contributes 10 percent of monthly basic salary, housing and transport, and the employee contributes 8 percent. Staff choose their own pension fund administrator and must give its details to Human Resources within 30 days of joining.

3.5 Professional development fund

Each full time member of staff may claim up to 150,000 naira in each academic year towards approved training, conferences or professional membership fees. Claims must be approved by the line manager before the cost is incurred.

If a member of staff leaves within 12 months of completing training costing more than 300,000 naira that the College paid for, they may be asked to repay a proportion of the cost, as set out in a training agreement signed before the course begins.

4. Leave Policy

4.1 Annual leave

Full time staff are entitled to 20 working days of paid annual leave in each leave year, in addition to public holidays. The leave year runs from 1 September to 31 August, matching the academic year.

After five years of continuous service, the entitlement rises to 24 working days. After ten years of continuous service, it rises to 26 working days. Part time staff receive annual leave in proportion to their contracted hours; a member of staff who works three days a week, for example, receives 12 working days.

Staff who join or leave part way through the leave year receive leave in proportion to the number of complete months worked in that year.

4.2 Booking annual leave

Annual leave must be requested through the staff portal at least 14 days in advance for periods of up to five days, and at least 30 days in advance for longer periods. Line managers should respond within five working days.

Teaching staff are expected to take most of their annual leave during the vacation periods between terms. Leave during teaching weeks is approved only in exceptional circumstances and requires the agreement of the Head of Faculty, because it affects students directly.

No more than two members of staff in the same team may be on annual leave at the same time without the agreement of the head of department.

4.3 Carrying over annual leave

Staff may carry over up to five unused days of annual leave into the next leave year. Carried over days must be used by 31 December, or they are lost.

Days beyond those five are lost at the end of the leave year unless the member of staff was prevented from taking them by sickness or by a written request from the College. In those cases, the line manager should confirm the extra carry over in writing to Human Resources.

The College does not pay staff in place of unused annual leave, except when employment ends, as described in Section 12.

4.4 Sick leave

Staff who are ill and unable to work receive full pay for up to 10 working days of sick leave in each leave year. Beyond that, sick leave is paid at half pay for a further 20 working days, and then unpaid.

For absences of up to two consecutive working days, staff may certify their own sickness by completing a short form on the staff portal when they return. For absences of three or more consecutive working days, a medical certificate from a registered doctor is required.

Where a member of staff has a long term illness, the College will work with them and their doctor to agree reasonable adjustments, a phased return to work, or a review of their duties. Decisions about long term absence are never made without a meeting with the member of staff.

4.5 Maternity leave

Female staff are entitled to 16 weeks of maternity leave on full pay, provided they have completed at least six months of service when the leave begins. Staff with less than six months of service receive 16 weeks of leave, with the first eight weeks on full pay and the remaining eight weeks on half pay.

Staff should tell Human Resources of their expected due date at least 12 weeks before it, and may choose to start maternity leave up to four weeks before the due date. Antenatal appointments are paid time off and do not count as sick leave.

On return from maternity leave, staff may work reduced hours of 6.5 hours a day for the first three months at full pay, to support breastfeeding and childcare arrangements.

4.6 Paternity leave

Male staff are entitled to 10 working days of paid paternity leave, to be taken within eight weeks of the birth or adoption of their child. Staff should give Human Resources at least four weeks' notice of their intention to take paternity leave where this is possible.

Paternity leave may be taken as one block or as two separate blocks of five days.

4.7 Compassionate and other special leave

Staff may take up to five working days of paid compassionate leave on the death of a spouse, child, parent or sibling, and up to two working days on the death of another close relative. Further unpaid leave may be agreed by the line manager.

Staff are entitled to one paid day of leave on their own wedding day, and up to three paid days in any leave year to sit professional examinations relevant to their role. Staff called for jury service or as a witness in court receive paid leave for the time required.

Unpaid leave of up to three months may be granted for personal reasons after two years of service, at the discretion of the Head of Human Resources.

4.8 Public holidays

Staff receive paid leave on all public holidays declared by the Federal Government. If a member of staff on a rota is required to work on a public holiday, they receive a replacement day off within the following four weeks.

5. Recruitment and Induction

5.1 Fair recruitment

The College recruits on merit. Every vacancy is advertised internally on the staff portal for at least five working days before or alongside any external advertisement, so that current staff have a fair chance to apply.

Interview panels have at least three members, including one person from outside the hiring department. Every candidate for the same role is asked the same core questions, and each panel member scores candidates independently before the panel discusses them.

Members of staff must declare any personal relationship with a candidate and must not sit on that candidate's interview panel.

5.2 Pre employment checks

Offers of employment are conditional on satisfactory references from two previous employers or, for first time employees, from one academic referee and one character referee. Offers are also conditional on verification of qualifications and, for roles involving students under the age of eighteen, a satisfactory background check.

5.3 Induction

New staff take part in a two day induction programme in their first week. It covers the College's mission, this handbook, health and safety, safeguarding, data protection and the staff portal. Lecturers also receive a one day teaching orientation from the Centre for Teaching Excellence.

Each new member of staff is assigned a buddy from their department for their first three months. The buddy is a friendly first contact for everyday questions and is not responsible for assessing the new member of staff.

5.4 Probation

All new staff serve a probation period of six months. The line manager holds review meetings at the end of the second month and the fourth month, and a final review before the end of the sixth month. Each meeting is recorded in writing and signed by both people.

Probation may be extended once by up to three months if more time is needed to assess performance. During probation, either the College or the member of staff may end employment by giving two weeks' notice in writing.

Staff on probation may not take more than five days of annual leave during the probation period without the agreement of the head of department.

6. Teaching and Academic Responsibilities

6.1 Teaching load

A full time lecturer teaches up to 18 contact hours a week during teaching weeks. The remaining hours are for preparation, marking, student consultations, curriculum development and departmental duties.

Lecturers must hold at least two consultation hours a week, published on their office door and on the student portal. Consultation hours may be held online by video call if the lecturer is working remotely on that day.

6.2 Marking and feedback

Coursework must be marked and returned to students with written feedback within 15 working days of the submission deadline. Final examination results must be submitted to the Examinations Office within 10 working days of the examination.

At least ten percent of each set of marked work, and every failing script, is second marked by another lecturer in the same department. Disagreements of more than ten marks are referred to the Head of Faculty.

6.3 Academic integrity

Lecturers who suspect plagiarism, collusion or the unauthorised use of artificial intelligence tools in student work must report it to the Academic Integrity Officer within five working days, using the reporting form. They must not apply their own penalty.

Students are allowed to use artificial intelligence tools only where an assessment brief explicitly permits it, and must declare how they used them. Lecturers should state the rules clearly in every assessment brief.

6.4 Student welfare

Lecturers are often the first to notice that a student is struggling. If you are concerned about a student's wellbeing, refer them to the counselling unit at the Freedom Way annex, or call the Student Welfare Officer directly if you believe the student is at immediate risk.

Staff must not offer private paid tuition to students they currently teach or assess.

7. Performance and Development

7.1 Annual performance review

Every member of staff has an annual performance review with their line manager in May. The review looks back on the year against agreed objectives and sets three to five objectives for the coming year.

Before the meeting, the member of staff completes a self assessment on the staff portal. Lecturers also include a summary of student feedback and a peer observation of their teaching.

The outcome is recorded as one of four ratings: exceeds expectations, meets expectations, partly meets expectations, or does not meet expectations. The rating informs the salary review described in Section 3.

7.2 Peer observation of teaching

Each lecturer is observed teaching by a colleague at least once a year and observes a colleague in return. Peer observation is developmental. Its notes are shared only between the two lecturers and are not used in disciplinary proceedings.

7.3 Support when performance falls short

Where a member of staff is not meeting expectations, the line manager first discusses the concerns informally and agrees what support is needed, such as training, mentoring or clearer instructions.

If performance does not improve within an agreed period, usually eight weeks, the line manager may start a formal performance improvement plan. The plan sets clear targets, the support the College will provide, and a review date. Only after a performance improvement plan has been completed without sufficient improvement may the matter be referred to the capability stage of Section 8.

7.4 Promotion

Academic staff may apply for promotion once a year, in February. Applications are assessed by the Promotions Committee against published criteria covering teaching quality, curriculum development, student outcomes and contribution to the College.

Applicants receive written feedback whether or not they are successful.

8. Discipline and Grievance

8.1 Principles

The College's disciplinary and grievance procedures aim to resolve problems fairly and early. Staff are always told the concern in writing before any formal meeting, are given the evidence, and have the chance to respond.

At any formal meeting, a member of staff may be accompanied by a colleague or a representative of the Staff Council. The companion may speak but may not answer questions on the member of staff's behalf.

8.2 Disciplinary stages

Minor concerns are handled informally by the line manager. Where formal action is needed, the stages are a first written warning, which remains on file for six months; a final written warning, which remains on file for twelve months; and dismissal.

Gross misconduct may lead to dismissal without notice, even for a first offence. Examples include theft, fraud, violence, sexual harassment, serious breach of student safeguarding, deliberate falsification of examination results, and being under the influence of alcohol or illegal drugs at work.

Before any decision is made in a case of possible gross misconduct, the member of staff may be suspended on full pay while the matter is investigated. Suspension is not a punishment and does not suggest that the College has reached any view.

8.3 Appeals

Staff may appeal against any formal disciplinary decision within 10 working days of receiving it in writing. The appeal is heard by a senior manager who was not involved in the original decision, and the appeal decision is final.

8.4 Raising a grievance

Staff who have a concern about their work, working conditions or relationships at work should first raise it informally with their line manager. If the concern is about the line manager, it may be raised with the next level of management or with Human Resources.

If informal discussion does not resolve the matter, the member of staff may raise a formal grievance in writing to Human Resources. A meeting will be held within 10 working days, and a written outcome given within five working days of the meeting.

Raising a grievance in good faith will never lead to any disadvantage for the member of staff.

9. Code of Conduct

9.1 Professional behaviour

Staff are expected to treat students, colleagues and visitors with courtesy and respect, to be punctual and prepared, and to dress in a way that is appropriate for a professional teaching environment. Smart casual dress is the norm; faculty heads may agree specific requirements for practical classes.

Staff must not discriminate against anyone on the grounds of ethnicity, religion, sex, disability, age or any other characteristic protected by law.

9.2 Relationships with students

Romantic or sexual relationships between staff and students are not permitted. A member of staff who has an existing relationship with a person who enrols as a student must declare it to Human Resources immediately, so that teaching and assessment arrangements can be changed.

Staff should communicate with students through College email and the student portal. Personal social media accounts must not be used to contact students individually, although official class groups set up through the College are allowed.

9.3 Gifts and conflicts of interest

Staff may accept small gifts of low value from students at the end of a course, such as a card or flowers. Gifts of money, or any gift worth more than 10,000 naira, must be politely declined or reported to the line manager.

Staff must declare any outside work, business interest or family connection that could affect, or appear to affect, their work at the College. Declarations are made on the staff portal and reviewed by Human Resources.

9.4 Use of social media

Staff must not post anything online that discloses confidential College information, identifies students without their consent, or could bring the College into disrepute. Staff who comment publicly on education matters should make clear that the views are their own.

9.5 Whistleblowing

Staff who believe there is wrongdoing at the College, such as fraud, danger to health and safety, or a cover up, should report it to the Head of Human Resources or, if that is not appropriate, to the Chair of the Board of Governors. Reports are treated in confidence, and no one who raises a concern in good faith will be penalised.

10. Health and Safety

10.1 Responsibilities

The College is responsible for providing a safe place to work and study. Every member of staff is responsible for working safely, following instructions, and reporting hazards. The Facilities Manager is the College's health and safety lead.

10.2 Reporting accidents and hazards

All accidents, injuries and near misses must be reported to the Facilities Office on the same day, using the incident form on the staff portal. Serious injuries must also be reported by telephone immediately.

First aid boxes are located at every reception desk and in each laboratory. A list of trained first aiders is displayed on every floor.

10.3 Fire and emergency procedures

Fire drills take place at least once each term. When the alarm sounds, lecturers lead their students out by the nearest exit to the assembly point in the main car park and take a register. Nobody may re enter the building until the fire warden gives permission.

Staff must never block fire exits or prop open fire doors.

10.4 Wellbeing support

The College offers all staff free and confidential counselling through an employee assistance programme, available by telephone at any time. Details are on the staff portal. Using the service is private and is not reported to line managers.

11. Information Technology and Data Protection

11.1 Acceptable use

College computers, email and internet access are provided for work. Reasonable personal use outside teaching time is allowed, provided it does not interfere with work, break the law or damage the College's reputation.

Staff must lock their screens when leaving their desks and must never share their passwords. Multi factor authentication is required on College email and the staff portal.

11.2 Protecting personal data

The College handles personal data about students and staff in line with the Nigeria Data Protection Act 2023. Staff must collect only the data they need, keep it secure, and share it only with people who have a legitimate reason to see it.

Student records, grades and welfare notes must be stored only in approved College systems, never on personal devices or personal cloud accounts.

11.3 Reporting a data breach

If personal data is lost, stolen or sent to the wrong person, staff must report it to the Data Protection Officer within 24 hours, even if they are unsure whether it is serious. Early reporting allows the College to limit the harm and meet its legal duty to notify the regulator.

11.4 Use of artificial intelligence tools

Staff may use approved artificial intelligence tools to help prepare teaching materials and administrative documents. They must not enter student personal data, unpublished examination questions or confidential College information into any tool that has not been approved by the IT Department.

Staff remain responsible for checking the accuracy of anything produced with the help of such tools.

12. Leaving the College

12.1 Resignation and notice periods

Staff who wish to resign must give notice in writing to their line manager and Human Resources. During probation, the notice period is two weeks. After probation, it is one month for administrative and support staff, and two months for academic staff.

Academic staff are asked, where possible, to time their resignation so that they leave at the end of a semester, to avoid disrupting students' studies.

The College gives the same notice periods when it ends employment, except in cases of gross misconduct.

12.2 Final pay

Final pay includes salary up to the last day of work, payment for any unused annual leave earned in the current leave year, and any allowances due. Any annual leave taken beyond the amount earned will be deducted.

Final pay is made on the next regular pay date after the member of staff leaves, provided all College property has been returned.

12.3 Exit interviews and references

Every member of staff who leaves is invited to an exit interview with Human Resources. The conversation is confidential and helps the College improve.

The College provides factual references confirming job title, dates of employment and, if requested by the member of staff, a summary of duties. Only Human Resources may give references on behalf of the College.

12.4 Returning College property

Before their last day, staff must return their identity card, keys, laptop and any other College property. The IT Department will close College accounts at the end of the last working day, so staff should save any personal files beforehand.

13. Contacts

13.1 Who to contact

Human Resources handles questions about contracts, leave, recruitment, probation and this handbook. The office is on the first floor of the Admiralty Way main building and can be reached at hr@lanternhill.example.

The Finance Office handles salary, allowances, pension and expense claims and can be reached at finance@lanternhill.example. The Facilities Office handles buildings, health and safety and incident reports at facilities@lanternhill.example.

The Data Protection Officer can be reached at dpo@lanternhill.example, and the IT service desk at itdesk@lanternhill.example. The Staff Council meets on the first Wednesday of each month and welcomes items from any member of staff.

All names, addresses and contacts in this handbook are fictional and were created for a software demonstration.